

*Trichosurus vulpecula*

## Common brush-tailed possum



**Length** 14–15½ in  
(35–58 cm)

**Tail** 10–16 in  
(25–40 cm)

**Weight** ¾–10 lb  
(1.5–4.5 kg)

**Location** Australia  
(including Tasmania)

**Social unit** Individual

**Status** Least concern



Familiar in many habitats, including parks and gardens, the common brush-tailed possum has mainly silver-gray body fur, which is short and tinged red in the north of its range, and longer and darker gray in the south. It bounds and climbs with ease as it forages for eucalypt, acacia, and other leaves, as well as flowers, fruit, and, occasionally, birds' eggs and chicks. This vocal possum, with its range of hisses, chitters, grunts, and growls, is solitary apart from the brief mating season. It lives in a crevice or hollow in a tree, log, rock, or roof. The usually single young remains in the pouch for 5 months.

*Phalanger orientalis*

## Northern common cuscus



**Length** 12–20 in  
(30–50 cm)

**Tail** 11–17 in  
(28–43 cm)

**Weight** ¾–11 lb  
(1.6–5 kg)

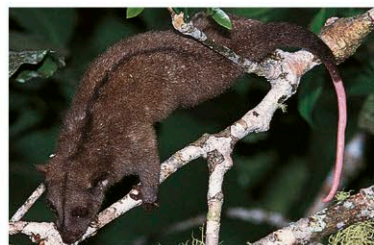
**Location** New Guinea,  
Solomon Islands

**Social unit** Individual

**Status** Least concern



The coloring of the northern common cuscus varies across its range of many islands, from almost white to black. There is generally, however, a stripe along the back, and part of the tail is always hairless and white. Resembling a combination of sloth and monkey, it has deliberate but agile climbing habits as it forages for leaves, fruit, and other plant material. Docile by nature, it is a common household pet.

*Gymnobelideus leadbeateri*

## Leadbeater's possum



**Length** 6–7 in  
(15–17 cm)

**Tail** 6–8 in (14.5–20 cm)

**Weight** ¾–6 oz  
(100–175 g)

**Social unit** Group

**Location** S.E. Australia  
(Central Highlands,  
Victoria)

**Status** Critically  
endangered



Notable for its rediscovery in 1961, after 52 years of presumed extinction, Leadbeater's possum has a gray back with a dark central stripe from head to tail, and off-white underside. Speedy and elusive in trees, it feeds at night on small invertebrates and tree juices, such as gum, sap, and nectar. Colonies of 10–12 individuals comprise a senior breeding pair and their offspring, mainly males. Females defend the group's territory.

*Petaurus norfolcensis*

## Squirrel glider



**Length** 7–9 in  
(18–23 cm)

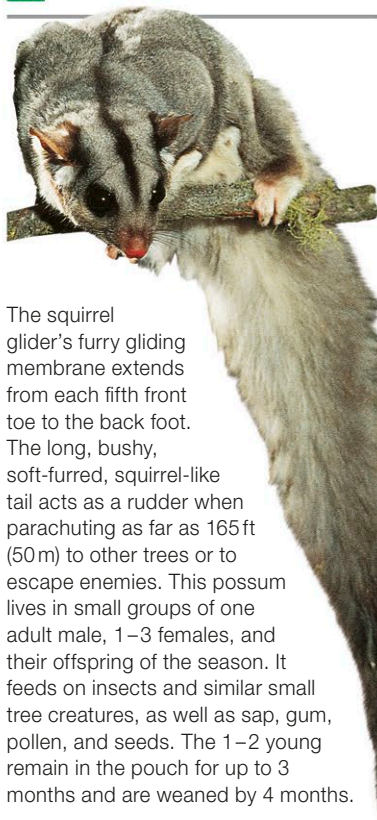
**Tail** 8¾–12 in  
(22–30 cm)

**Weight** 7–11 oz  
(200–300 g)

**Location** E. Australia

**Social unit** Group

**Status** Least concern



The squirrel glider's furry gliding membrane extends from each fifth front toe to the back foot. The long, bushy, soft-furred, squirrel-like tail acts as a rudder when parachuting as far as 165 ft (50 m) to other trees or to escape enemies. This possum lives in small groups of one adult male, 1–3 females, and their offspring of the season. It feeds on insects and similar small tree creatures, as well as sap, gum, pollen, and seeds. The 1–2 young remain in the pouch for up to 3 months and are weaned by 4 months.

*Dactylopsila trivirgata*

## Striped possum



**Length** 9½–11 in  
(24–28 cm)

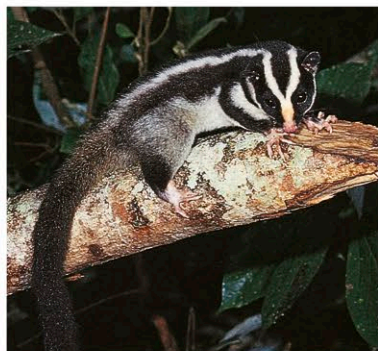
**Tail** 12–15½ in  
(30–39 cm)

**Weight** 11½–20 oz  
(310–545 g)

**Location** N.E. Australia,  
New Guinea

**Social unit** Variable

**Status** Least concern



Skunklike black and white stripes and a bushy, black, white-tipped tail are the distinguishing features of the striped possum. Like the skunk (see panel, p.186), it can emit a foul, penetrating odor from glands in the genital region. At night, it forages alone through tree branches, probing for wood-boring grubs, ants, and termites with the extra-long claw on its front fourth toe. It also eats fruit, birds, and small mammals.

*Hemibelideus lemuroides*

## Lemuroid ring-tailed possum



**Length** 12–16 in  
(30–40 cm)

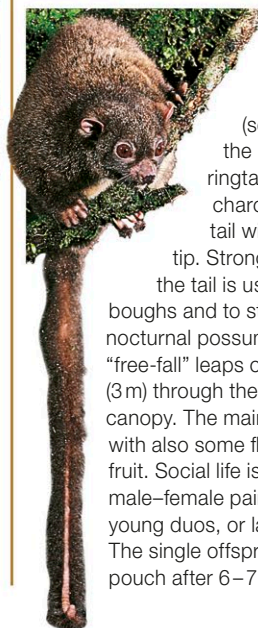
**Tail** 12½–14½ in  
(32–37 cm)

**Weight** 29–43 oz  
(800–1,200 g)

**Location** N.E. Australia

**Social unit** Variable

**Status** Near threatened



Lemurlike in the face and body proportions (see pp.138–9), the brushy-tailed ringtail has a long, charcoal-colored tail with a hairless tip. Strongly prehensile, the tail is used to grip boughs and to steer as this nocturnal possum makes “free-fall” leaps of some 9 ft (3 m) through the rainforest canopy. The main diet is leaves, with also some flowers and fruit. Social life is flexible, with male–female pairs, mother–young duos, or larger groups. The single offspring leaves the pouch after 6–7 weeks.

*Pseudocheirus peregrinus*

## Common ringtail



**Length** 12–14 in  
(30–35 cm)

**Tail** 12–14 in  
(30–35 cm)

**Weight** 25–39 oz  
(700–1,100 g)

**Location** E. Australia,  
Tasmania

**Social unit** Group

**Status** Least concern



The common ringtail's reddish or gray-brown fur extends to the base of the tapering, strongly prehensile tail, becomes darker along the first half of the tail, then changes to white. Found in many habitats, including parks and gardens, the main food of this group-dwelling mammal is leaves, especially eucalypts and acacia. In the north of its range, it nests in a tree-hole; in the south, in a squirrel-like drey.